돌려서 말하기: 진짜 뜻은 뭘까요?

This worksheet shows common Korean phrases that refuse, ask, or disagree indirectly, and what they really mean.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

By the end, you can read an indirect Korean line and tell whether it is a soft refusal, a hidden request, or a polite sign to finish.

1 WHY KOREANS OFTEN SAY IT THE LONG WAY

In Korean, a plain 'no' such as 안 돼요 or 싫어요 can sound cold, especially to older people, coworkers, or new friends. So people often refuse, ask, or disagree in a roundabout way. The listener is expected to find the real meaning from the situation.

In Korean, lines like 'I'll think about it' or 'Let's eat sometime' are often not meant literally. When someone answers a request or invitation, watch for these clues: 좀, -(으)ㄹ 것 같아요, a sentence that stops in the middle (...), or a reason with no clear answer. Together they often mean 'no'.

2 PHRASES AND THEIR REAL MEANING

1	**생각해 볼게요** (I'll think about it)	Often a polite 'no', especially to a sales offer or an invitation. 예: 가격이 좀 비싸네요. 생각해 볼게요.
2	**좀 어려울 것 같아요** (that might be hard)	A soft way to say 'I can't do it.' 예: 금요일까지는 좀 어려울 것 같아요.
3	**그날은 좀...** (that day is a bit...)	Stopping in the middle tells the listener the answer is no. 예: 아, 그날은 제가 좀...
4	**괜찮아요** (no, thanks)	When someone offers something, it often means 'no, thanks', not 'good'. 예: 더 드릴까요? — 아니요, 괜찮아요.
5	**다음에 밥 한번 먹어요** (let's eat sometime)	A friendly goodbye; it is usually not a real plan with a date. 예: 오늘 반가웠어요. 다음에 밥 한번 먹어요.
6	**혹시** (by any chance)	Opens a question or request softly. 예: 혹시 이 근처에 약국 있어요?
7	**바쁘신데 죄송하지만** (sorry to bother you, but)	A cushion you say before asking for help. 예: 바쁘신데 죄송하지만, 이것 좀 봐 주실 수 있어요?
8	**좀 춥지 않아요?** (isn't it a bit cold?)	A question about the room that is really a request, like closing a window. 예: 창문이 열려 있네요. 좀 춥지 않아요?
9	**그건 좀 그렇네요** (I'm not sure about that)	Shows you disagree or don't like an idea without saying why. 예: 회의를 일요일에 해요? 그건 좀 그렇네요.
10	**시간이 벌써 이렇게 됐네요** (oh, look at the time)	A polite sign that you want to finish or leave. 예: 어머, 시간이 벌써 이렇게 됐네요. 슬슬 일어날까요?

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3 HOW TO REFUSE AN INVITATION SOFTLY

1. **고마움 말하기** (Thank them for asking)
2. **미안함 말하기** (Say you are sorry)
3. **이유 말하기** (Give a short reason)
4. **부드럽게 거절하기** (Say no softly (좀, -(으)ㄹ 것 같아요))
5. **다음 약속 제안하기** (Offer another time)

These phrases are common in everyday Korean, but tone and situation always decide the real meaning.

4 YOUR TURN

FIND THE REAL MEANING

Read each Korean line and decide what the speaker really means, wants, or should say.

1 Read the message. What does 민지 really mean?
(a) She probably won't come.
(b) She will surely come.: 토요일 모임이요? 그날은 일이 좀 있어서요. 일단 생각해 볼게요.

2 Is the speaker asking you to do something? Write Yes or No:
①(at night, in your room) 이 방이 좀 어둡네요.
②주말에 본 영화가 정말 재미있었어요.
③(at a bank counter) 아, 펜을 안 가져왔네요...

3 Fill in the blank with a soft refusal using -(으)ㄹ 것 같아요:
죄송하지만 이번 주는 바빠서 같이 가기는 ____.

4 Put the sentences in order, following the steps in 'How to refuse an invitation softly':
(A) 다음 달에는 꼭 갈게요. (B) 초대해 줘서 고마워요. (C) 그날 부모님이 오셔서요. (D) 이번에는 좀 힘들 것 같아요.

5 At a team dinner, your manager says this. What does the manager really want?
(a) to order more food
(b) to end the dinner: 다들 내일 일찍 출근해야 하죠? 오늘 정말 즐거웠어요.

✓ ANSWERS

1) (a) She probably won't come.
2) ① Yes (turn on the light) ② No ③ Yes (lend a pen)
3) 어려울 것 같아요 (좀 어려울 것 같아요 / 힘들 것 같아요)
4) B → C → D → A
5) (b) to end the dinner

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